

● SCORECARD · 25 QUESTIONS · 1 TO 5 GRID · RED FLAGS

PR Agency *Evaluation* Scorecard

Twenty-five questions to ask any PR agency or consultant before you sign, grouped into team, results, process, pricing and contract. Each comes with what a good answer sounds like. Score every candidate on the same grid and the decision usually makes itself.

HOW TO SCORE

1. Ask every candidate all 25 questions, ideally in two calls: one with the pitch team, one with the person who will run your account.
2. Score 1 (poor or evasive) to 5 (specific, evidenced, honest) for each answer.
3. Any red flag from the last page counts as a veto regardless of total score.
4. Use one copy of this scorecard per candidate.

BEST FOR

Founders hiring their first PR agency or fractional PR lead

TIME

Two 45-minute calls per candidate plus reference checks

SCORING

Maximum 125. Above 100: strong. 75 to 100: probe weak areas. Below 75: pass.

Candidate: _____ Date: _____ Interviewed by: _____

#	QUESTION	1	2	3	4	5
Team · Who actually does the work						
1	Who will run my account day to day, and how many other accounts do they handle? Good answer: A named senior person with a manageable load. Vague answers mean a junior after the pitch.					
2	Can I meet that person before signing? Good answer: Yes, without hesitation.					
3	What is their direct experience in my category (Web3, AI, security)? Good answer: Specific launches, outlets and beats they know, not a list of logos.					
4	Which journalists in my space have they worked with recently, and on what? Good answer: Examples of stories and relationships, shared without breaching confidences.					
5	What happens if my lead leaves or is on leave? Good answer: A named backup and a documented handover.					
Results · What they have done and can prove						
6	Show me three campaigns for companies at my stage. What was the goal and what happened? Good answer: Goals tied to outcomes, honest about what did not land.					
7	Can I speak to two current clients and one former client? Good answer: Yes. Former clients are the more honest reference.					
8	How do you measure success beyond coverage counts? Good answer: Message pull-through, target-outlet hits, referral traffic, AI citations, pipeline influence.					
9	What share of your coverage is earned versus paid or sponsored? Good answer: A clear, honest split. Paid placements should be labelled as such.					
10	Tell me about a campaign that underperformed. What did you change? Good answer: A real story with a lesson. Agencies with no failures are not telling you everything.					
Process · How they will work with you						
11	What will you do in the first 30 days? Good answer: Discovery, messaging, media list, angle memo, first pitches. A concrete plan.					
12	How do you decide which story angles to pitch? Good answer: Starts from what reporters and readers need, not from your announcement list.					
13	How will you prepare our founders for interviews? Good answer: Message house, mock interviews, briefing notes before every call.					

#	QUESTION	1	2	3	4	5
14	What will reporting look like, and how often? Good answer: Weekly or biweekly, focused on decisions and next actions, not only activity.					
15	What do you need from us, and how much founder time per week? Good answer: An honest estimate. PR without founder access does not work.					
Pricing · What you pay and what it includes						
16	What exactly does the retainer include and exclude? Good answer: Written scope: pitching, content, events, wire fees, travel, tools.					
17	Are there extra costs for distribution, wires, tools or travel? Good answer: Listed up front with typical amounts.					
18	How is a launch sprint priced compared with a retainer? Good answer: Clear difference in scope and duration. (For reference, fractional retainers often run \$5K to \$12K per month and focused launch sprints \$15K to \$40K; agencies vary.)					
19	Do you offer or recommend pay-per-placement or guaranteed coverage? Good answer: No guarantees of editorial coverage. If they guarantee placements, ask whether they are paid.					
20	What does a realistic first 90 days of output look like for our budget? Good answer: Specific expectations that do not overpromise.					
Contract · Terms that protect you						
21	What is the minimum term and notice period? Good answer: A short initial term or a trial period, then 30 days notice.					
22	Who owns the media lists, content and assets created? Good answer: You do, delivered on exit.					
23	Do you work with any of my direct competitors? Good answer: A clear answer and a conflict policy.					
24	How are confidentiality and embargoes handled in writing? Good answer: NDA in place; embargo handling described.					
25	What happens if we are not happy after 60 days? Good answer: A defined review point with a way out.					

TOTALS

Score summary

SECTION	MAX	CANDIDATE A	CANDIDATE B	CANDIDATE C
Team	25			
Results	25			
Process	25			
Pricing	25			
Contract	25			
Total	125			
Red flags (any = veto)	0			

VETO

Red flags

- ☐ **Guaranteed coverage** in named outlets. Editorial coverage cannot be guaranteed; guarantees usually mean paid or sponsored placements presented as earned.
- ☐ **Bait and switch.** Senior people pitch, but cannot commit to working on your account.
- ☐ **Reporting by volume.** Success measured in "impressions", "potential reach" or syndicated wire pickups instead of target-outlet stories.
- ☐ **Mass blasting.** They plan to send your release to hundreds of contacts or "our database of 50,000 journalists".
- ☐ **No references,** or only references from clients signed in the last month.
- ☐ **No category knowledge.** Cannot name reporters on your beat or recent stories they wrote.
- ☐ **Long lock-in** (6 to 12 months) with no performance review point or exit.
- ☐ **Ownership grab.** They keep the media lists, content or accounts when you leave.
- ☐ **Compliance shrug.** For token, financial or security products, no process for legal review of claims or for disclosed paid promotion.
- ☐ **Undisclosed conflicts** with a direct competitor.
- ☐ **Fake social proof.** Logos of companies they never worked with, or "as seen in" badges for paid placements.
- ☐ **No questions for you.** A good partner interrogates your story before they agree to pitch it.

● NEXT STEP

Want a senior operator *on your launch?*

Templates get you organised. Coverage, citations and pipeline come from judgement: which angle a journalist will actually take, which channel deserves the next dollar, and what to cut.

Book a 30-minute teardown. Bring your launch plan, your positioning or your last campaign and leave with a prioritised list of fixes.

Book a 30-minute teardown: shilikajain.com/contact

Six years

PR and go-to-market for Web3, AI and cybersecurity founders.

50+ protocols

Launches, funding rounds and token events supported.

Tier-1 outlets

Forbes, CoinDesk, Cointelegraph, Decrypt, The Block, Blockworks, AI Magazine.

Prefer to self-serve first? Try the free interactive planners, budget calculator and checklist at shilikajain.com/tools. More downloads live at shilikajain.com/resources.

Engagements: fractional PR retainer \$5K to \$12K per month. Launch sprint \$15K to \$40K.